African Indigenous Spirituality takes its place in the global academy

African Hidden Voices at the CESNUR International Conference, Taiwan, Sunday 11 October 2026. The first in a series of research articles from the conference.

By African Hidden Voices (AHV) Research Institution

For most of the last century, African spirituality entered the international study of religion through a door built by others. It was named “African Traditional Religion” by a Methodist missionary inside a university department, studied under categories developed in Europe, and set beside the world's religions as a smaller and older cousin. Since 2023, at four consecutive CESNUR International Conferences, African Hidden Voices has been reversing that arrangement. On Sunday 11 October 2026, in Taiwan, the reversal reached a new point: the categorical distinction between African Indigenous Spirituality and “African Traditional Religion” was argued not in a plenary devoted to African spirituality, but in the conference's ordinary comparative programme, beside scholars of other traditions, as one subject among the subjects the academy studies.

The conference

The Center for Studies on New Religions, CESNUR, was founded in Turin in 1988 by Dr Massimo Introvigne and is the leading international network of scholars working on new religious movements, religious freedom and the relationship between religion and the State. Its annual conference moves between continents and gathers researchers from universities across Europe, Asia, Africa, Australia and the Americas. The 2026 conference, “Religions and New Spirituality in East Asia and Beyond: Grand Master Hunyuan Chanshi Memorial Conference”, was hosted by the Weixin Shengjiao Merit Foundation at Weixin Shengjiao College in Nantou County and the Weixin Shengjiao Taichung Branch Temple, and co-organised by CESNUR and the International Society for the Study of New Religions.

African Hidden Voices (AHV) Research Institution was represented by Dr Khumbulani Sibanda. Sunday 11 October was the day of AHV's principal scheduled contribution.

In Session 12, “Colonial and Post-Colonial Perspectives, Mission, and Dialogue”, chaired by Bernard Doherty and scheduled from 17:00 to 18:45, Dr Sibanda presented “A Categorical Distinction between African Indigenous Spirituality (AIS) and African Traditional Religion (ATR)”. The paper asked whether the term “African Traditional Religion” is able to carry the depth, scope and philosophical character of African spiritual worldviews at all, and argued that it cannot: a classification coined within comparative religion describes the practices it was built to see and misses the system of knowing beneath them. The terminology used to describe African spiritual systems shapes how they are studied, interpreted and represented, in the academy and in public

discourse, and the paper set that question inside the wider debate on colonial knowledge production, indigenous epistemologies and the representation of African worldviews in comparative religious studies.

Dr Sibanda presented alongside Mordechai Miller of Ben-Gurion University of the Negev, on Jewish spirituality in colonial Singapore; Geraldine Smith of the University of Tasmania, on generational change in the multifaith movement; and Laurentiu Tanase of the University of Bucharest, on new religious movements in Romania. The day's wider programme ranged from Shincheonji and the Ahmadi Religion of Peace and Light to Daesoon Jinrihoe and contemporary East Asian spiritual traditions, the comparative setting in which the classification of African spiritual systems could be examined.

The following day the subject was given a plenary of its own, Session 18, “African Indigenous Spirituality and Anti-Cultism in South Africa”, chaired by Dr Introvigne. There Dr Sibanda presents the book from which the Sunday paper is drawn, *African Indigenous Spirituality versus African Traditional Religion: Religion as a Colonial Category and the Recovery of an Indigenous Ontology* by HSRM Imboni Dr uZwi-Lezwe Radebe, to the plenary. That session will be reported in the next article in this series.

Why this matters for AHV

AHV was established as a research institution with a global mandate: to study African Indigenous Spirituality from within, to publish that research to the standard the international academy recognises, and to correct, in the record, what colonial and mission scholarship wrote about African spiritual systems. Each CESNUR conference has advanced that mandate. Taiwan advanced it in three ways.

The first is visibility of a new kind. In Vilnius, Bordeaux and Cape Town, AHV's research was heard in plenaries built around The Revelation Spiritual Home and African Indigenous Spirituality. In Taiwan it was placed in the same thematic session as papers from Ben-Gurion University, the University of Tasmania and the University of Bucharest, and discussed in the same room, on the same footing. AHV's position on the categorical distinction between AIS and ATR is now part of the international literature as an argument in comparative religion, with a date, a venue and a programme entry that any scholar can check.

The second is the terms of the discussion. The paper did not ask to have African Indigenous Spirituality admitted to the category of “African religions” or “indigenous religions”. It asked whether the category fits at all, and it put that question in a session on colonial and post-colonial perspectives, which is where it belongs. The pairing is exact. The reason the distinction between AIS and ATR matters in South Africa today is that the State is drafting frameworks for the religious sector, and a spiritual system filed under religion will be regulated as religion. AHV's research reached the conference at the moment the question is live.

The third is what comes after. The report from the day records the openings the conference created: journal articles, further conference papers, comparative research and structured engagement with scholars working on indigenous knowledge systems and spirituality. A research institution grows through exactly these channels, and after four years AHV is established in them.

AHV went to Taiwan with five objectives: to present and advance research distinguishing AIS from ATR; to contribute African perspectives to international academic discussion on religion, spirituality and indigenous knowledge; to promote recognition of AIS as an indigenous worldview and knowledge system; to engage international scholars working on comparative religion, new religious movements and religious freedom; and to identify opportunities for academic collaboration, research dissemination and institutional partnership. Each of the five was met on the first day.

The scholar, and where he comes from

Something should be said plainly about the scholar who stood at the podium in Taichung, because it explains how AHV came to be there at all.

The categorical distinction that Dr Sibanda put to the international academy was not found in the academy. It is the argument of the first book in the African Indigenous Spirituality Series, *African Indigenous Spirituality versus African Traditional Religion*, by HSRM Imboni Dr uZwi-Lezwe Radebe, published by Isambulo Publications in 2026, whose subtitle, “Religion as a Colonial Category”, readers of the paper will recognise. It was taught by HSRM, who received it, set it out in the book series, and formed the scholars who now carry it. The presentation is the work of a school of thought, and the school has a source.

This is worth stating because of what it means for the future. A single paper at a conference is an event. A body of scholars, trained in a system of knowing, publishing from a shared foundation, presenting year after year among researchers from five continents, and co-organising the conference when it comes to Africa, is a field. HSRM's teaching has produced that field, and AHV is its research institution. The academy's own record attests it: a Cambridge University Press study of The Revelation Spiritual Home, a Global Spirituality Award conferred in Turin, and four years of plenaries and sessions. None of these conferred HSRM's standing; they recognised it. What CESNUR has provided is a platform on which the restoration of African spiritual identity can be seen by the people whose textbooks will describe it next.

The road to Taiwan

Taiwan was AHV's fourth consecutive CESNUR conference. Read backwards from 2026, the record shows how the ground was prepared.

Cape Town, November 2025. The conference came to Africa, and AHV co-organised it with CESNUR, the African Forum for Religious and Spirituality Liberty and the International Society for the Study of New Religions. HSRM Imboni Dr uZwi-Lezwe Radebe gave the welcome address and the concluding

remarks. A plenary introduced *The Revelation Spiritual Home: The Revival of African Indigenous Spirituality*, the study by Massimo Introvigne and Rosita Šorytė published by Cambridge University Press in its Elements in New Religious Movements series, with Sam Langa presenting for AHV on the universal concept of spirituality as influenced by African Indigenous Spirituality, and HSRM responding. The conference field trips took the world's scholars of religion to The Revelation Spiritual Home itself.

Bordeaux and Turin, 2024. At CESNUR in Bordeaux in June, the plenary “Next Year Under the South African Sky: African Prophecy, African Spirituality, and CESNUR 2025” carried papers by Tshidiso Gama and Palesa Hloele for AHV and Thembi Tulwana for The Revelation Spiritual Home, with Dr Introvigne presenting on HSRM and the origins of The Revelation Spiritual Home. A month earlier, in May, HSRM had received the Global Spirituality Award from Fedinsieme at the Turin International Book Fair for his work in restoring African Indigenous Spirituality.

Vilnius, June 2023. CESNUR gave a plenary session to The Revelation Spiritual Home, “Rethinking 'Spirituality' in an African Context”, in which Palesa Hloele presented for the African Hidden Voices Research Institute on the history of African Indigenous Spirituality, alongside papers by Dr Introvigne, Rosita Šorytė and Karolina Maria Hess.

Each year prepared the next: a plenary on The Revelation Spiritual Home in 2023, a plenary announcing the South African conference in 2024, a conference co-organised in Africa in 2025, and in 2026 a paper in the ordinary comparative programme of the international study of religion.

What follows

This is the first of a series of research articles from the conference. The articles that follow will set out the argument of the paper in full, report the discussion that followed it, record the questions raised by scholars from other traditions together with AHV's answers, and cover the plenary session of Monday 12 October.

For now, the record stands as follows. On 11 October 2026, in Taiwan, in AHV's fourth consecutive year at CESNUR, African Indigenous Spirituality was argued in the ordinary comparative programme of the international study of religion as a system of knowing in its own right, by a scholar formed within it. That is where the subject now stands, and it will not return to the smaller door.